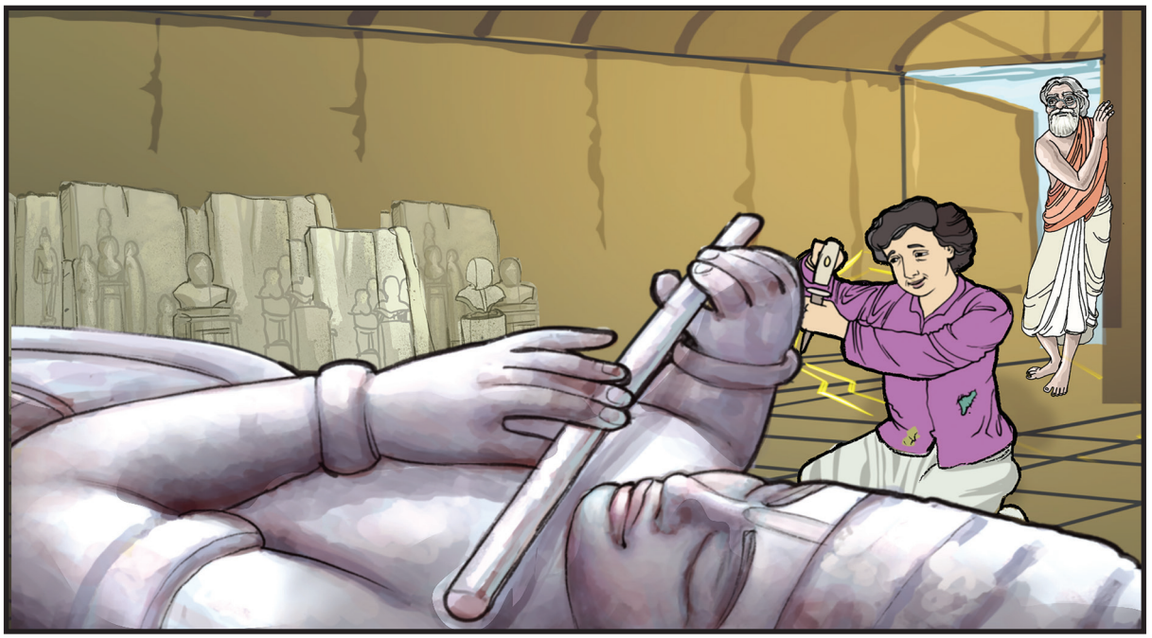
Section III



From the workshop, the chipping sound of the chisel reached his ears. He listened. Had his ears deceived him? No, He could hear it again – the strong blow of the hammer on top of the chisel.

Gopal! He was back! Gopal had returned. He would help him. They would finish the statue! He **stumbled** to his feet, crossed the small room and reached the door.

"Gopal!" He was about to shout when the words froze on his lips. "No!" he wanted to cry out " Stop! Stop the work!."

But he couldn't move. Shock had **immobilised** him. He stood staring at the back of the young stone carver working on the face of the statue, on the eyebrows, arching over a pair of fine eyes.

But it wasn't his son sitting cross-legged before the biggest statue he had ever carved. It was Salim, his servant.

The old man watched stunned. The first wave of shock, fear and anger passed to give way to a feeling of great relief and happiness.

"Hai Ram," the old man whispered "Hai Ram" and **tottered over** to the boy. Dropping his hand on his shoulder he said softly, " Salim."

The **startled** boy turned and looked up at his master. He rose to his feet clumsily, the hammer and chisel still in his hands.

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